

STAGE TEN • RELATIONSHIPS & CONNECTIONS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Ten • Relationships & Connections

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Ten is the most personally revealing stage in the program so far. It asks participants to reflect honestly on real friendships, real team conflicts, and real gaps in their professional networks. Part 4 of this script (Tricky Moments) is especially important here — review it before facilitating, not just during.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get uncomfortable, stuck, or reluctant to share.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

“Welcome to Stage Ten. Everything we've built so far — your skills, your brand, your business acumen — sits inside relationships. Today we start with the most personal ones: real friendships.”

“This stage asks for more honesty than most. We're going to reflect on real friendships, real conflicts, and real gaps in how we show up for people. Nothing here requires you to share more than you're comfortable with — I'll always tell you clearly when something is opt-in.”

Opening Session 2

“Last time was about friendships that exist because you chose them. Today is about relationships you're placed into by circumstance — project partners and teammates — and how to make those genuinely work.”

“If you're currently in a real group project, hold onto it in your mind throughout today. Almost everything we cover will be more useful applied to something real than something hypothetical.”

Opening Session 3 (Stage Close)

“Our final session moves from peers to people ahead of you — mentors and professional connections. This is often the relationship category people feel least confident about, so expect some real hesitation, including your own.”

“We'll close today by looking back across the entire stage, not just this session. Keep in mind what we covered in Sessions 1 and 2 as we go.”

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST N1 → N2

"You've identified a friendship worth genuinely investing in. Investment has to run both ways — let's look at what real, reciprocal support in that friendship actually looks like."

FIRST N4 → N5

"We just worked through something hard — unaddressed tension. Let's balance that with something that should be easier, but that most people still forget to do: genuine appreciation."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Everything today was about relationships you chose. Next session shifts to ones you're placed into — project partners and teams — which need a different, more structural kind of care."

FIRST N13 → N14

"Now that the team is aligned on the actual goal, let's put that alignment to work on a real problem together."

FIRST N18 → N19

"Conflict, when addressed well, is only half the picture. The other half is making sure we're just as deliberate about recognizing what's going right."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You've built real skill working alongside peers. Session 3 looks up and out — mentors and professional contacts who aren't peers, but who can meaningfully shape where you're headed."

FIRST N21 → N22

"Identifying the right person is only step one. A mentor relationship that never gets scheduled never actually becomes real — let's fix that today."

FIRST N24 → N25

"You now know how to sustain one mentor relationship. Let's zoom out to a broader structure — a small peer circle that gives you more than one source of support and perspective."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

Someone is reluctant to name a real, unaddressed conflict (FIRST N4)

"You don't have to name who it's with or what it's about. Just naming to yourself that it exists, and that it's worth addressing, is enough for today's exercise."

A participant says they don't have a strong friendship to reference for N1

"That's genuinely useful information, not a failure. This might be less about deepening an existing friendship and more about identifying a newer connection worth deliberately investing in — let's work with that instead."

Someone feels they have nothing to offer a potential mentor (N21-N22)

"Mentorship isn't only for people who feel fully ready. Genuine curiosity and follow-through are what most mentors actually respond to, not a polished resume."

A participant dominates group problem-solving (N14) without realizing it

"Let's pause and make sure we've genuinely heard the other person's full reasoning before moving to a solution — that's actually the point of this exercise."

The room goes quiet during a reflection prompt about friendship or team conflict

"That's okay — these are genuinely harder to answer out loud than most of what we've covered. Take a moment, and know you can also just write it down rather than share verbally."

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS (one a full arc) where participants commonly get stuck, defensive, or reluctant — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST N4

Conflict Resolution with a Friend

FACILITATOR NOTE

This can bring up real, sometimes painful, unresolved tension. Never require anyone to name specifics of the conflict to the group. If someone becomes visibly distressed, offer a private check-in rather than addressing it in front of everyone.

FIRST N9

Trust-Building Exercise

FACILITATOR NOTE

Vulnerability exercises in a workshop setting carry real risk if pushed too far. Keep any live version explicitly low-to-moderate stakes (see the Graduated Disclosure Circle in the Group Versions document) and never ask participants to share something they haven't clearly opted into.

FIRST N18

Conflict Mediation in a Team

FACILITATOR NOTE

Participants may have a genuine, currently unresolved team conflict they're tempted to process live in the room. Redirect this to a private conversation with you after the session rather than turning the group session into real-time mediation of someone's actual dispute.

FIRST N21-N24

Mentor Identified through Follow-Up (full arc)

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants, especially those newer to a field or without existing professional networks, may feel genuine anxiety that they don't know anyone who could serve as a mentor. Have a few concrete, accessible starting points ready (academic advisors, alumni networks, professional associations) rather than leaving this feeling unreachable.